JONATHAN ZEMPEL

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Summary

Design systems leader with 10+ years building scalable component platforms. I created and grew Zendesk Garden from zero to 95%+ UI adoption across the product suite, architected a federated contribution model spanning dozens of distributed teams, and shipped the component set that became the foundational UI layer for Zendesk's generative AI app builder. I bring deep expertise in component architecture, design-to-engineering workflows, accessibility, and the organizational strategy required to make a design system stick.

Experience

Zendesk, San Francisco, CA **Apr '14 – Mar '26**

Sr. Principal Engineer

- Created Garden, Zendesk's open source design system (Figma + React), from scratch — now the source of truth for UI standards across all products
- Scaled Garden into the foundational UI layer for Zendesk's generative AI app builder — fueling a new product line powered by AI-generated interfaces
- Built and led a cross-functional team of engineers and designers maintaining zero-regression core libraries
- Architected a federated contribution model that scaled Garden to 95%+ of all UI interactions across dozens of globally distributed teams
- Spearheaded Zendesk's accessibility initiative, embedding WCAG 2.2 AA compliance into the primitive component layer
- Delivered the component set that powered Zendesk's 2026 unified navigation across eight products

Pickwick & Weller, San Francisco, CA **Aug '12 – Apr '14**

Lead Developer

- Built the full mobile web experience (jQM) and led a major e-commerce redesign for a fashion startup
- Shifted the team from manual deploys to continuous deployment
- Authored open-source Stamps.com and FedEx shipping APIs for order fulfillment

Genomera, Palo Alto, CA **Feb '10 – Aug '12**

Architect

- Architected an internet-scale social platform modernizing clinical trials using DNA-based health data
- Built the full stack (HTML5/CSS/JS, Python, MongoDB) and deployed to production multiple times daily from day one

Skills

- *Technologies:* React, Vite, Storybook, Tailwind CSS
- *Languages:* TypeScript, HTML/CSS, Python, Java, SQL
- *AI Tooling:* Claude, Copilot, Storybook MCP, Figma Make